



▲ Protective words

Medieval amulets, such as this one, had magic words inscribed on their metal plates. They were hung around the neck to ward off evil spirits, or bring good fortune to the wearer.

Kame'a (amulets) were commonly worn as protection against such spirits. Foxtails and crimson threads were popular amulets, while an even tekumah (preserving stone) was carried to prevent miscarriage.

Amulets were often written on, so that they contained what were considered the most powerful elements of Jewish magic—words.

Some were religious texts, such as copies of Psalm 126, which were placed about the house to protect children. Others included the names of angels, or traditional magical phrases etched on a metal plate and hung around the neck.

Pieces of furniture or household items were sometimes given protective inscriptions, too.

One especially powerful talisman was the Seal of Solomon, the star-shaped symbol that medieval writers claimed was engraved on Solomon's signet ring by God. The seal reportedly gave Solomon the power to control *shedim*. The star could have either five or six points, and the way the triangles interlaced was said to make demons dizzy.

Kabbalah

The word “kabbalistic” is often used today to mean secretive or mysterious, but the root of the word—Kabbalah—is a Jewish mystical way of thinking that aims to understand, connect with, and even influence the divine. Kabbalah emerged in 1230 with a book called the *Zohar*. The Spanish rabbi who discovered this text claimed that it was the 1,000-year-old teachings of a 2nd-century sage. The *Zohar* was thought to reveal hidden meanings— aspects of the divine—in the Torah (the first five books of the Tanakh), and studying these meanings carefully was believed to enable the reader to achieve a mystical union with God.

The academic, theological side of Kabbalah was hugely important in Jewish thinking during the centuries that followed. However, there was another side, known as “practical Kabbalah,” which aimed to influence the world, rather than simply come closer to the divine. From the 14th century onward, practical Kabbalah followers put into practice the idea of using the names of God and the angels to make amulets or to form part of their incantations. They incorporated other Jewish occult traditions, too, including oneiromancy (dream divination) and ideas about demons: for example, the 15th-century kabbalistic book *Sepher ha-Mashiv* (“Book of God's Wind”) described how to use incantations to summon demons, angels, and even God.

IN PRACTICE

Medieval Jewish love spells



As was common practice in many cultures, Jewish people in the medieval period often turned to magic to help with love, using amulets, rituals, and magic words, which carried great significance. An amulet's inscription might invoke lovers from the Tanakh, such as Abraham and Sarah or Isaac and Rebecca, to encourage love. Conversely, to end love the inscription might invoke Eve or Amnon, who raped his half-sister Tamar. Some used metaphors, such as words for burning, to stimulate desire. One spell advised would-be lovers to fill an eggshell with their own blood and that of their beloved, and then to write both names in blood on the shell and bury it— instant results were promised.

Abraham tells Sarah that God has promised them a child in this 14th-century English manuscript; the couple were often alluded to in love spells.